

What Happens When You Can't Check the Box? Categorization Threat and Public Opinion among Middle Eastern and North African Americans

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Middle Eastern and North African (MENA) Americans are politically visible yet institutionally invisible, long categorized as “white” by the U.S. government despite neither self-categorizing nor racially assigned as such. Most forms—across public and private sectors—still lack a “MENA” category option. What are the political consequences of institutional invisibility? Across two survey experiments and in-depth interviews, I find that exclusion from official identity categories triggers the experience of categorization threat, a psychological response rarely linked to political behavior. When MENA Americans experience categorization threat, they respond by expressing opinions on politics in ways that attempt to signal and assert their MENA identity and, to a lesser extent, Person of Color (POC) identity. Such identity assertion demonstrates that bureaucratic categorization influences expressions of public opinion on politics, not simply how people self-categorize. Researching the effects of category exclusion on public opinions creates opportunities for more accurate and democratic scholarship.

INTRODUCTION

There is little doubt that identities play an important role in shaping public opinion on politics (Achen and Bartels 2016; Berelson, Lazarsfeld, and McPhee 1954; Campbell et al. 1960; Huddy 2001; Kinder and Kalmoe 2017). People have multiple identities and the salience of any one of those identities depends upon various contexts. This is particularly the case for people's ethnoracial identities (for example, Appiah and Gutmann 1998; Beltrán 2010; Crenshaw 1990; d'Urso 2022; Davenport 2018; 2020; Dawson 1995; Huddy 2001; Lajevardi 2020; Lee 2008; Masuoka 2017; Masuoka, Ramanathan, and Junn 2019; Omi and Winant 2015; Pérez 2021a; Wong et al. 2011).¹ Political institutions play an important role in influencing ethnoracial identity expression (Espiritu 1992; Lopez 1997; Marx 1998; Mora 2014; Nobles 2000; Omi and Winant 2015; Schachter, Flores, and Maghbouleh 2021). State-sanctioned identity categories, including but not limited to ethnorace, are created through a fraught political process between multiple actors: “Categories emerge not from one particular source but rather from the interactive relationships between sets of actors” (Mora 2014, 11). The identity categories institutions recognize and formally adopt shape the salience of identities in surprising ways (Marx 1998; Mora 2014;

Nobles 2000). This is especially true for individuals who self-identify with a group but are not able to self-categorize—or label themselves—accordingly because their group is not institutionally recognized (Barreto et al. 2010; Cheryan and Monin 2005; Fath and Proudfoot 2024; Townsend, Markus, and Bergsieker 2009).² Examples of this can be found across many different identity groups including ethnorace and gender. Before the 2000 Census, individuals with multiple ethnoracial backgrounds could only self-categorize with one group (Davenport 2018; 2020; Masuoka 2017; Nobles 2000; Prewitt 2013; Williams 2006). Today, individuals who identify beyond the gender binary are not always able to self-categorize on important forms or identification cards. The mismatch between identification and categorization also affects Middle Eastern and North African (MENA) Americans.³

² Self-identification is how one sees one's identity, regardless of the labels commonly used or institutionalized. Self-categorization, on the other hand, involves how people label their identities.

³ There is no universal definition of which countries define the “MENA.” I define the MENA as all Arab-majority countries and include the non-Arab majority countries of Turkey, Iran, and Afghanistan. There is a distinction between terms like “Arab,” “MENA,” or “SWANA” (Southwest Asian and North African). The popularity of “Arab” arose from regional pan-Arabism in the early 1960's and subsequently made its way to the US thereafter; however, the regional movement died down as each group became more concerned with national politics (Mohamedou 2018; Naber 2012; Reiser 1983). This opened the door for “MENA” to gain more popularity within the US. Unlike “Arab,” the categories “MENA” and “SWANA” are inclusive of non-Arab ethnic minorities from the region including but not limited to Amazighs, Berbers, Copts, Kurds, Persians, Turks. The racialization of MENA individuals in the US is such that these individuals are all seen as one ethnoracial group despite the fact that many are not ethnically Arab. “MENA” has explicit roots in colonialism, but the term “SWANA”, attempts to move away from this. Even so, most MENA Americans are familiar with and

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Received: March 22, 2024; revised: April 02, 2025; accepted: June 20, 2025.

¹ Race and ethnicity are both social constructs that nevertheless impact individuals in society (Omi and Winant 2015, 110). I use the term “ethnoracial” to sit at the intersection of the ambiguities within socially constructed identities.

MENA Americans occupy a paradoxical position in the United States. They are one of the most politically visible groups in the US. They are subjected to increased surveillance (Akram and Johnson 2003; Beydoun 2015a; Maira 2014), stereotyped as subhuman (d'Urso 2022; Kteily and Bruneau 2017; Kteily et al. 2015; Kteily, Hodson, and Bruneau 2016), and have unique healthcare needs from other ethnoracial groups (Abuelezzam 2020; Dallo et al. 2023; El-Sayed and Galea 2009). Yet MENA Americans are also rendered invisible due to their ethnoracial categorization. From 1977 to 2024, MENA individuals were legally categorized as "White."^{4,5} Although the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) issued a directive in 2024 for all federal agencies to update their minimum racial categories to include "MENA," until there is a U.S. census with a "MENA" category, the existing demographic information on MENA Americans is limited.⁶

Generally, MENA individuals are not perceived to be ethnorracially White (d'Urso 2024; Maghbouleh 2025; Schachter, Flores, and Maghbouleh 2021) nor do they identify as such (Awad, Hashem, and Nguyen 2021; d'Urso 2022; Maghbouleh 2017; Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022; Naber 2000; 2012). Despite this, it is rarely the case that demographic questionnaires include "Middle Eastern or North African" as a racial category. Ironically, this institutional disenfranchisement brings MENA identity to the forefront, making it more salient for MENA individuals. Given that MENA identity is both racialized and politicized (Aziz 2022; Bayoumi 2006; d'Urso and Bonilla 2023; d'Urso 2022; 2024; Dana et al. 2019; Hobbs and Lajevardi 2019; Lajevardi and Oskooii 2018; Lajevardi 2020; Maghbouleh 2017; Naber 2000; 2012; Oskooii, Dana, and Barreto 2021; Tehranian 2000), how does the inclusion or exclusion of a "MENA" category affect how MENA individuals respond to political questions?

self-categorize themselves as "MENA" instead of "SWANA." Finally, the OMB has amended its minimum racial categories to include the group "MENA," which many advocacy organizations support (Orvis 2024). As such, I also refer to this group as "MENA."

⁴ I use quotations around the ethnoracial labels when talking about them as categories from which one may self-select. I do not include quotations when discussing how people identify or when identifying others. For example, until 2024, the federal government categorized MENA individuals as "White," but most MENA Americans self-categorize as "MENA."

⁵ I capitalize "White" to contribute to the "racing" of Whiteness (Painter 2020).

⁶ The OMB is in charge of designating the minimum racial categories that the federal government must use when collecting data on race. The OMB's Statistical Policy Directive Number 15 outlines the standards for collecting federal data on race and ethnicity. In March 2024, they issued a revision that includes "MENA" as a distinct racial category. As a result of this change, all federal agencies that collect data on race or ethnicity were given 18 months to update their categories to align with these changes. They allowed for these agencies to file for an extension of this implementation until March 28, 2029. This means that although there has not been a U.S. Census that includes "MENA," all other agencies, including the Census, must update their racial categories in the meantime.

To test the relationship between institutional category recognition or denial on political attitudes, I draw on two survey experiments fielded in April 2022 and October 2024 through January 2025 on MENA Americans (d'Urso 2025). These data are unique because without a widely adopted ethnoracial category, MENA individuals are considered hard-to-survey populations (Awad, Kia-Keating, and Amer 2019). From these two experiments, I find that when MENA individuals are unable to self-categorize as "MENA," they experience categorization threat, a form of social identity threat when individuals' social identities are miscategorized (Barreto et al. 2010; Branscombe et al. 1999; Townsend, Markus, and Bergsieker 2009). Categorization threat is the real-world status quo for MENA Americans, because they are rarely given forms that include "MENA" as an option, even after the OMB's revisions. In response to categorization threat, MENA individuals respond by asserting their MENA identity within the confines of the survey environment (Cheryan and Monin 2005). They express stronger support when answering questions related to MENA identity (such as foreign affairs in the MENA region), and this assertion also seems to extend to issues concerning people of color more generally (Pérez 2021a).

On the other hand, when MENA individuals' ethnoracial category is affirmed and they are allowed to self-categorize as such, their responses to political questions are, overall, statistically equivalent to when their identity is not made explicitly salient (e.g., when they are not asked to self-categorize). This suggests when individuals with identity categories that are not included by default have the opportunity to meaningfully self-categorize their identities, they express opinions about politics in ways that reflect day-to-day attitudes. People's identities are often salient in guiding beliefs, even when their identity is not explicitly asked about.

To supplement the survey experiment and ground the findings in the real world, I also present results from interviews with MENA Americans conducted from 2022 through 2025. Even across diverse backgrounds, the MENA Americans I interviewed expressed frustration when they are unable to self-categorize themselves as "MENA." This frustration leads some to express feeling invisible, consistent with categorization threat. They subsequently reacted to this experience by trying to assert their identity within the constraints of a survey format. These findings provide insight into the construct validity of categorization threat and identity assertion found in Studies 1 and 2.

We may think of forms asking people to categorize their identities—such as on the Census, at the Department of Motor Vehicles, on mortgage applications, or doctors' offices—as tedious, bureaucratic impositions. However, these demographic data are essential to governing the people being enumerated (e.g., directing federal funding, understanding trends in illnesses, redistricting, voting blocs, etc.). The identity categories available on most forms are largely drawn from the standards set by the federal government—even when the form is not issued by the federal government.

Whereas prior research has shown that the inability to self-categorize one's identity in meaningful ways leads to negative emotional reactions (Barreto et al. 2010; Fath and Proudfoot 2024), this article draws a link between the denial of a politicized identity and its consequences on political opinions related to the identity that was denied. In addition to re-substantiating that MENA Americans prefer to self-categorize as "MENA," MENA identity is politically meaningful for issues that target their group—both foreign and domestic—with spillover to issues that relate to people of color, more broadly. Beyond the question of which categories we should use to group people, I show the consequences of not including categories that align with people's identities. This is particularly important as society recognizes the multifaceted and expansive nature of identities.

MENA AMERICAN IDENTITY

MENA Americans are a politically salient, highly visible, and growing demographic group. The Arab American population—an ethnic subset of the MENA American population—is estimated at 3.7 million alone (Maghbouleh 2025; Arab American Institute N.d.). For context, this is roughly the same number of Muslim Americans. However, relatively little is known about MENA Americans as compared to other minority ethnoracial groups. This is in part because until 2024 MENA individuals were legally categorized by the federal government as "White," with no census data possible until 2030. Despite this longstanding categorization, MENA Americans have experienced steady racialization out of their former "White" designation into a distinct "MENA" identity group (Alsultany 2012; Beydoun 2013; 2015a; 2015b; d'Urso 2022; 2024; Gualtieri 2009; Maghbouleh 2017; 2020; Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022; Naber 2000; 2012; Shaheen 2003; Tehranian 2000; 2007; 2009).

But MENA Americans did not always aim to be categorized as "MENA." In the early 1900s, the law required that—in addition to other eligibility requirements—only immigrants who were racially "Black" or "White" could naturalize (Immigration and Ethnic History Society 2019). Any individual who was not either "Black" or "White" was deemed ineligible for naturalization. This left immigrants with more ambiguous ethnoracial identities to petition the courts to argue that they should be granted naturalization because they were racially "White" (Beydoun 2013; Coulson 2017; Gualtieri 2009; Lopez 1997; Wang 1997). MENA immigrants were among those who petitioned naturalization agencies and immigration judges to grant their naturalization requests on the grounds that they were "White." A majority of the cases involving MENA petitioners were heard between 1909 and 1928 and ruled that MENA individuals were eligible to naturalize because they were racially "White" (Coulson 2017; d'Urso 2024; Gualtieri 2009; Lopez 1997). However, for MENA Americans, the institutional designation as "White" was tenuous.

Historians point to two main factors contributing to the shift from "White" to "MENA," and both are

inextricably linked with the racial thinking surrounding Muslim identity (Meer 2013; Muldoon 2000; Ramey 2014; Stepan 1982; Thomas 2010). Indeed, the racialization and politicization of Muslims exacerbated the racialization and politicization of MENA identity, making it impossible to understand the latter without the former (Aziz 2022; Bayoumi 2006; Chouhoud 2022; Chouhoud, Dana, and Barreto 2019; Collingwood, Lajevardi, and Oskooii 2018; Considine 2017; d'Urso and Bonilla 2023; Dana and Lajevardi 2025; Dana et al. 2019; Dana, Barreto, and Oskooii 2011; Dana, Wilcox-Archuleta, and Barreto 2017; Galonnier 2015a; Garner and Selod 2015; Jamal and Sinno 2009; Lajevardi and Abrajano 2019; Lajevardi and Oskooii 2018; Meer 2013; Oskooii, Dana, and Barreto 2021; Sediqe 2025). First, the earliest MENA immigrants to the US were primarily Christian, but beginning in 1945, MENA immigrants were more likely to be Muslim (Kayyali 2006). Due to the proximity of Christianity to Whiteness and longstanding tropes connecting Islam with non-Whiteness, Muslim MENA immigrants were racialized as non-White (Aziz 2022; Bayoumi 2006; Coulson 2017; d'Urso and Bonilla 2023; d'Urso 2024; Galonnier 2015b; Husain 2019; Meer 2013; Muldoon 2000; Oskooii, Dana, and Barreto 2021; Ramey 2014). Second, US involvement in conflicts in the MENA region, particularly beginning in the 1970s, shaped how American society perceived MENA individuals. These geopolitical conflicts continued to interlink Muslim and MENA identities in ways that situated both as "non-White" outsiders (d'Urso 2022; Gualtieri 2009; Kayyali 2006; McAlister 2005; Naber 2000; Shaheen 2003; Tehranian 2009).

The September 11 attacks, therefore, did not catalyze the racialization of MENA and Muslim Americans, but it did reinforce and expedite it. Particularly after 9/11, mass media portrayed *both* MENA and Muslim individuals as terrorists and threats to American security (Alsultany 2012; Chouhoud 2022; Lajevardi 2020; McAlister 2005; Naber 2012; Oskooii, Dana, and Barreto 2021; Shaheen 2003; Tehranian 2009; Terman 2017). Moreover, the number of hate crimes toward Muslims and MENA individuals—including people *perceived* to be either Muslim or MENA—increased significantly (Abdelkarim 2003; Kaplan 2006; Maghbouleh 2025).⁷ Thus, the racialization of MENA Americans away from their legally designated category is not a 21st-century phenomenon but a process that has spanned nearly 100 years. These decades-long processes mean that MENA Americans are simultaneously extremely visible within U.S. society yet invisible throughout American institutions.

MENA Americans are aware of their racialization. They know that they are not generally perceived as White and prefer to self-identify (d'Urso 2022) and self-categorize as "MENA" (d'Urso 2022; Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022; Mathews et al. 2017; see

⁷ Ironically, some of these hate crimes had to be categorized as nationality-based because White-on-White crimes could not be categorized as race-based hate crimes (Maghbouleh 2017).

supplementary results in Section B of the Supplementary Material). For instance, findings from the 2020 Cooperative Multiracial Post-election Survey (CMPS) show that a majority of MENA individuals sampled said that their racial identity was important to them (Section F, Table F.54 in the Supplementary Material) and that they consider their racial identity as central to their sense of selves. MENA individuals were as likely to select their racial identity as they were to select their religious identity as the group most important to their sense of personal identity and ranked both identities as highly important (see Section F, Table F.62 in the Supplementary Material).

Responding to the shift in self-categorization, civic organizations such as the Arab American Institute had petitioned the federal government to add a MENA category as early as the 1990s. By 2015, the Census Bureau conducted a category test, concluding that the OMB should add “MENA” as a distinct ethnoracial group (Mathews et al. 2017). However, this effort did not materialize in a category on the 2020 Census. When the OMB revisited this possibility in 2022 and 2023, they continued to work with a number of civic organizations (such as the Arab American Institute and the American–Arab Anti-Discrimination Committee), met with focus groups, and received comments from thousands of MENA individuals in favor of the change (Orvis 2024). Recognizing the need and desire for a “MENA” category, the OMB updated the federal minimum racial categories. In March of 2024, the OMB altered Directive 15 to include “Middle Eastern or North African” as a distinct, federally-recognized racial group (Orvis 2024). Along with this announcement, they gave all federal agencies 18 months to implement these changes; however, it also allowed agencies to file for extensions to implementing these changes until as late as March of 2029.

This article does not ask *whether* MENA Americans see themselves as “MENA” instead of “White.” Extant research shows that they do (Awad, Hashem, and Nguyen 2021; d'Urso 2022; Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022; Mathews et al. 2017). Rather, what are the political and psychological consequences of categorizing MENA individuals as “White” given their desire to self-categorize as “MENA” but the notable absence of a corresponding ethnoracial category on demographic surveys?

SELF-CATEGORIZATION THEORY (SCT)

Research in social psychology demonstrates that group identity plays a crucial role in shaping behavior and attitudes (Hogg and Abrams 1988; Tajfel and Turner 1979; Turner 1982). Group identities help people organize and navigate interactions with others. An essential aspect of group identity is being recognized as a member within a given group, along with the concomitant meaning or emotional significance of that membership (Brewer 1999; Tajfel 1981). Membership in a group can be anything as small as being told one is in group A or B, as in the Minimal Group Paradigm (Tajfel et al.

1971), or being a fan of a sports team. But it also includes social groups that become politicized, such as groups based on religion, sexual orientation, gender identity, and ethnorace (Huddy 2002).

Self-categorization Theory (SCT), one of the main theoretical branches of social identity theory, provides a framework for understanding the consequences of categorization with a certain group (Turner 2010). Notably, SCT involves thinking of each group identification as nested within a hierarchy of other groups (Sindic and Condor 2014). This means that at any point in time, different memberships can be more salient relative to others, and the *context* under which these identities are made salient can enhance people's identification with their group (Huddy 2002). Environmental stimuli can temporarily heighten the salience of one's social identity, thereby influencing one's actions to be in line with the norms and behaviors of that group (Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje 1997; Ellemers, Kortekaas, and Ouwerkerk 1999; James 1890; Turner 2010). Thus, when a given social identity is activated, people categorize themselves and those around them into constructed group norms. An activated social identity, therefore, may lead one to follow “beliefs, attitudes, feelings, and behaviors that optimally minimize in-group differences and maximize intergroup differences” (Terry and Hogg 1996, 779) and to “act as a group” (Turner et al. [1987, 42] in Huddy [2002, 132]). Numerous studies have shown how manipulating the salience of different social identities influences people's attitudes and behaviors (Bargh, Chen, and Burrows 1996; Bradburn, Sudman, and Wansink 2004; Dijksterhuis and Van Knippenberg 1998; Druckman, Kuklinski, and Sigelman 2009; Hopkins 2014; Sayre 1939; Schwarz, Strack, and Mai 1991; Shih, Pittinsky, and Ambady 1999; Steele and Aronson 1995; Steele and Ambady 2006; Turner and Krauss 1978).

People's social identities have been shown to drive their political attitudes (see, for example, Althaus and Coe 2011; Harrison and Michelson 2015; Klar 2013; Klar, Madonia, and Schneider 2014; Levendusky 2017; Lacombe, Howat, and Rothschild 2019). When one recognizes their identity as politically important, that identity is politicized in addition to the personal or cultural significance it holds. Individuals rely on their identification with different social groups to reach coherent attitudes about politics (Achen and Bartels 2016; Berelson, Lazarsfeld, and McPhee 1954; Campbell et al. 1960; Dawson 1994; Kinder and Kalmoe 2017). Politicized identities also aid people in understanding how politics directly or indirectly impact their lives. SCT posits individuals have multiple social identities that can become salient depending on context (Althaus 2006; Bargh 2006; Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje 2002; Huddy 2002). Sometimes these identities are politicized and sometimes they are not. Systematically manipulating identity salience is a common treatment used in survey experimental contexts to better understand the relationship between individuals' social identities and their opinions on politics. For example, making ethnoracial identity salient can influence people's evaluation of political issues and partisanship (Abrajano 2010; Benjamin, Choi, and Strickland 2010;

Jackson 2011; Ostfeld and Pedraza N.d.; Shih, Pittinsky, and Ambady 1999; White 2007). The salience of one's identity can be manipulated in any number of ways, including the context under which people are asked to self-categorize (Ostfeld and Pedraza N.d.) or by the options available from which they can self-categorize (Fath and Proudfoot 2024).

Identity Categorization

There is a subtle but important distinction between self-identification and self-categorization. Self-identification involves how individuals understand and claim their own identities. Identification does not necessarily need a formal or shared set of labels that out-group members would use and recognize (Brodkin 1998). Self-categorization, on the other hand, involves the labels people adopt to describe their group, particularly in an institutionalized setting. It is often the case that these labels are assigned to groups by *other* groups, emerging either from social practice or institutional designation. These labels are not merely adopted by out-group members but are often adopted by in-group members, unless they “actively resist” the label (Branscombe et al. 1999, 38–9). Ellemers, Kortekaas, and Ouwerkerk (1999) discuss the three parts of Tajfel's (1978) definition of a social identity. This includes the cognitive (e.g., self-categorization), the evaluative (e.g., positive or negative), and the emotional (e.g., commitment) (Ellemers, Kortekaas, and Ouwerkerk 1999, 372). They note that although social identity typically refers to the emotional component, it is just as important “to distinguish cognitive awareness of one's group membership *per se* (*self-categorisation*) from the extent to which one feels emotionally involved with the group” (Ellemers, Kortekaas, and Ouwerkerk 1999, 372–3). Therefore, not only is there a conceptual difference between self-identification and self-categorization, but a psychological one as well.

For individuals with identities that are not institutionally categorized, *both* the absence *and* the presence of their identity label will make their identity salient. On the one hand, the experience of identifying with a group but being unable to self-categorize with that group heightens the salience of that identity. On the other hand, when individuals who are typically unable to self-categorize with their identity *are* given the opportunity to self-categorize, the divergence from the status quo can also heighten the salience of that identity. What are some of the consequences resulting from identity salience as a result of one's category being absent (i.e., *status quo*) or present (i.e., *status novus*) when one's identity category is usually absent? Below, I consider how identity categorization can influence individuals' responses to relevant stimuli via two contrasting concepts: categorization threat and categorization affirmation.

Categorization Threat

When individuals are miscategorized or are unable to self-categorize in ways that are meaningfully aligned with their identities, they experience a threat to their social identities and identity denial. This specific type of threat is referred to as categorization threat

(Barreto et al. 2010; Branscombe et al. 1999; Townsend, Markus, and Bergsieker 2009). Importantly, “categorization threat is not dependent on the existence of negative group stereotypes. Instead, the threat is caused by a mismatch between the category that others use and the category that we prefer” (Barreto et al. 2010, 44). Thus, regardless of whether the group has a positive or negative connotation associated with it, if people identify with that group, they want to be recognized as a part of that category.

People experience categorization threat in many ways: being categorized in the right group at the wrong time or with the wrong group altogether. Categorization threat can occur in social settings but also when there is a mismatch between institutional categories and the categories people want to use for themselves. Categorization threat not only makes one's identity salient, it also elicits a number of reactions as a result. Research has shown that when individuals have a preferred identity categorization, being miscategorized can lead to anger (Fath and Proudfoot 2024), protest (Barreto et al. 2010), and a re-assertion of their identity (Cheryan and Monin 2005; Leach et al. 2010). This leads me to pose:

Hypothesis 1a. MENA individuals experiencing categorization threat will engage in identity assertion when answering political questions, holding all else constant.⁸

Categorization Affirmation

Less research has considered the psychological consequences of an affirmative category option. Social identity affirmation, as opposed to social identity threat, occurs when in-group and out-group members embrace positive expressions of a given individual's social identity (Wang et al. 2024, 810). Categorization affirmation captures the phenomenon of an individual being categorized in ways that match an identity that is often rendered invisible. For individuals occupying identities that are and have been institutionally recognized, this affirmation may go unnoticed. For example, someone who is a cisgender woman, self-categorizing as a woman on a form is a type of category affirmation, but it may not make her gender identity particularly salient since there is an expectation that her category will always be available. However, for individuals occupying identities that do not always have institutionally-recognized or widely-used categories, the ability to self-categorize in ways that align with one's identity is a form of category affirmation that *does* make that identity more salient. The deviation from the *status quo*—including the category—is as likely to be noticed by only those for whom the category is relevant as when the category is absent.

Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje (2002) give some insight into the mechanism underlying categorization affirmation. They discuss the social psychological

⁸ The language of this hypothesis has been altered from the preregistration entitled “H1” for clarity and can be found in Section D.1 of the Supplementary Material. See Section E.4 of the Supplementary Material for more information on deviations from preregistration.

responses to individuals who are committed to their group (i.e., self-identify with a group) when their group is not threatened. They argue that under the condition of no threat, those who self-identify with their group will want to engage in “identity expression” (Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje 2002, 167). They say, the “importance of group identity [under this context] means the primary concern here will be to express and affirm this identity” (169). As such, identity assertion depends on whether the group identity is fully formed or still developing. If the group identity is still developing, individuals will engage in behavior that will “attempt to create a distinctive identity by distinguishing and differentiating the group from out-groups in the comparative context” (Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje 2002, 167). Individuals may behave in ways that they believe will underscore how their group would behave, seeking to differentiate themselves from other groups. This leads me to pose an alternative hypothesis to H_{1a} , above:

Hypothesis 1b. MENA individuals experiencing categorization affirmation will engage in identity assertion when answering political questions, holding all else constant.⁹

Identity Assertion

Both hypotheses argue that for individuals without a widely adopted identity-group label, the absence or presence of that label will make the identity salient. As a result of this identity salience, individuals will engage in identity assertion. Identity assertion refers to behaviors that are related to affirming one's membership with their group. Individuals might engage in behaviors that are in line with their identities under a number of circumstances but particularly when their identity is made salient or questioned (Barreto et al. 2010; Cheryan and Monin 2005; Trujillo, Garcia, and Shelton 2015). For instance, research found that when individuals were questioned about their ethnoracial identity, they were more likely to report engaging in activities such as eating foods or wearing clothing associated with their racial and ethnic cultures (Trujillo, Garcia, and Shelton 2015).¹⁰

Identity assertion occurs in ways that align with the salient group. This includes changing “one's behavior to appear more prototypical by engaging in prototypical behavior or displaying evidence of past

prototypical behavior. This could lead to changing one's speech patterns (Shepard, Giles, and Le Poire 2001), attitudes (Branscombe et al. 1999; Jetten et al. 2003), and preferences (DeBono 2000; Sherman and Gorkin 1980; Tafarodi, Kang, and Milne 2002) to come closer to the in-group's prototype” (Cheryan and Monin 2005, 718). Identity assertion should be seen relative to issues that are specifically related to the identity being made salient. For example, when MENA identity is made salient either through categorization threat or categorization affirmation, MENA respondents are not merely giving their *opinion* on that issue, they are answering questions about politics in a way that will convey that they are a MENA respondent. Thus, identity assertion should relate to issues that affect the MENA community domestically, but also issues that relate to the MENA region abroad. Moreover, as mentioned, Muslim and MENA identity, although distinct, are deeply intertwined. This means identity assertion should also extend to issues related to Muslim identity in addition to MENA identity. On the other hand, responses to issues that do not convey MENA identity—such as the economy—will not change as a result of categorization threat or categorization affirmation. This is because answering questions about the economy does not allow for MENA individuals to assert a MENA identity in the same ways as opinions about foreign affairs in the MENA region and/or about Muslims would.

The question remains, however, whether identity assertion is limited to MENA identity alone. What is the scope of identity assertion? Research has suggested that many non-White Americans are connected with the pan-ethnoracial label “Person of Color” (POC); when people of color are primed to consider their identity as being a part of a broader group, they are more likely to support other people of color outside of their specific ethnoracial groups (Eidgahy and Pérez 2023; Pérez 2021a; Pérez et al. 2023; 2024; Pérez 2021b). This relationship has also been found in MENA Americans (Eidgahy and Pérez 2023). This leads me to pose my second hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2. Identity assertion will occur on issues related to POC identity but not on issues unrelated to (POC/MENA) identity, holding all else constant.¹¹

Whereas hypotheses 1a and 1b detail an expectation to observe identity assertion along MENA identity-related issues, hypothesis 2 extends the scope beyond the specific group being made salient to the broader category in which that group resides.

Observable Mechanism: Response Substitution

Hypotheses 1a, 1b, and 2 discuss identity assertion as the outcome of interest. But what is the mechanism

⁹ The language of this hypothesis has been altered from the original preregistration entitled “H3” for clarity and can be found in Section C.1 of the Supplementary Material. See Section E.4 of the Supplementary Material for more information on deviations from preregistration.

¹⁰ Yet, it may be that instead of identity assertion, these treatments could have the opposite effect. It is possible that categorization threat could dampen responses due to a feeling of invisibility or that their group does not matter. On the other hand, categorization affirmation could dampen responses due to a feeling of hyper-visibility. However, the extensive literature in social psychology tends to provide the strongest evidence in favor of the process of identity assertion.

¹¹ This hypothesis was not specifically addressed in preregistration. See Section E.4 of the Supplementary Material for more information on deviations from preregistration.

through which this can be observed? In a survey context, individuals are unable to express themselves outside of the constraints imposed by researchers. When taking surveys, individuals do not always answer questions in ways that researchers expect. Rather, sometimes individuals respond to survey questions in ways that reflect the “beliefs they want to convey but the researcher has not asked about” (Gal and Rucker 2011, 185). For example, in the absence of a “MENA” category, researchers might expect MENA individuals to self-categorize as “White.” But MENA respondents may reject this assumption and decide to self-categorize as “Other” or skip the question altogether. The act of shifting response options in an attempt to convey one’s beliefs is referred to as “response substitution” (Gal and Rucker 2011).

Response substitution is a specific form of response bias when individuals wish to express their opinions but are unable to do so because the questions being asked of them are not specifically related to the attitude they wish to convey. In the absence of being able to self-categorize in meaningful ways, these hypotheses are tested by assessing the extent to which individuals engage in identity assertion observed through response substitution.

STUDIES

I use a mixed-methodological approach to assess the impact of categorization threat and affirmation on identity assertion among MENA Americans. Studies 1 and 2 are survey experiments that manipulate categorization threat and categorization affirmation to assess the causal impact of these treatments on responses to various political questions related to MENA identity, POC identity, or unrelated to these identities. I find support for hypotheses 1a and 2 and fail to reject the null for hypothesis

1b. The inability to self-categorize as “MENA” leads MENA individuals to engage in identity assertion (via response substitution) on both MENA-related and POC-related political questions but not on questions unrelated to these identities. Categorization affirmation, on the other hand, leads MENA individuals to answer political questions in ways that align with how they would answer those same questions under the condition when they were not asked to self-categorize at the outset of the study.

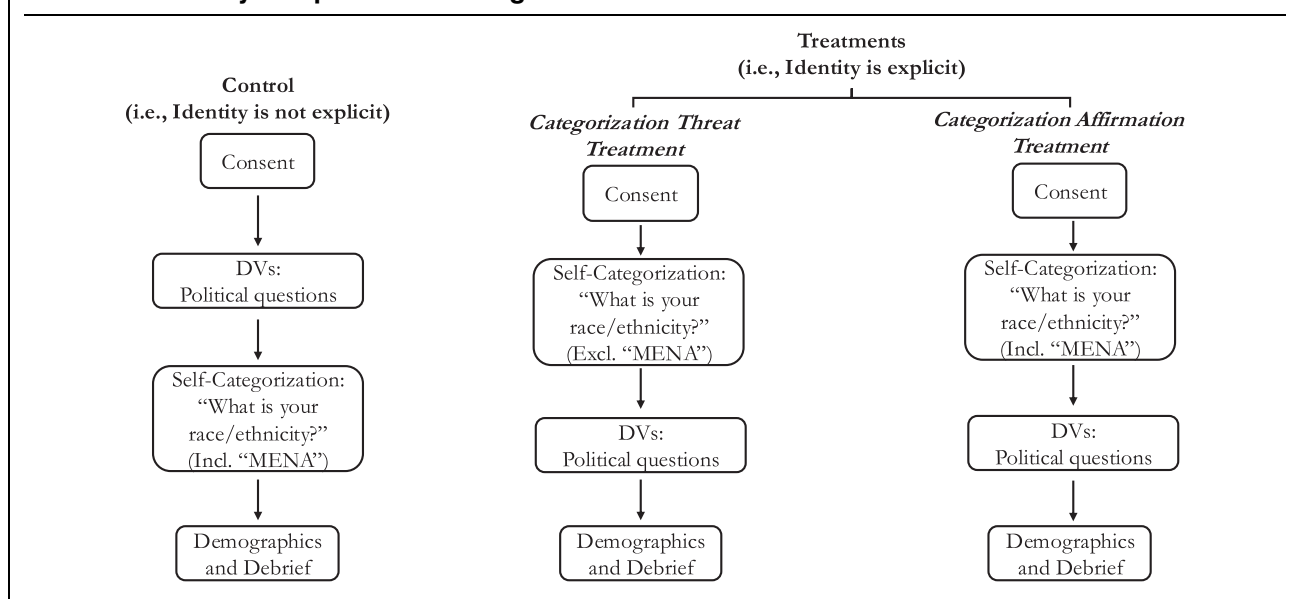
Study 3 provides qualitative evidence from in-depth interviews with a diverse group of MENA Americans to show that MENA individuals experience categorization threat when they are not given the option to self-categorize as “MENA.” Some interviewees continued by sharing that experiencing categorization threat led them to engage in some form of response substitution as a means of identity assertion.

Study 1

Study 1 was conducted from April 5–22, 2022 via YouGov for a total of 400 MENA respondents. This design is a three-condition experiment embedded in an online survey fielded to individuals who were *pre-identified* by YouGov to be of Middle Eastern or North African heritage. Figure 1, below, visualizes the design.

In the control condition, MENA respondents are asked their opinions on various political questions immediately after consenting to the study but *prior* to being asked to self-categorize their ethnoracial identity. When respondents in the control are finally asked to self-categorize their identity, “MENA” is included as a response option. The two treatment conditions, on the other hand, ask respondents to self-categorize their ethnoracial identity immediately after consenting to the study. In the categorization threat condition, “MENA” is not given as an option for respondents to select. In the

FIGURE 1. Study 1 Experimental Design



categorization affirmation condition, “MENA” is given as an option. Alongside ethnoracial category options listed, all three conditions also included “some other race.” After self-categorizing their ethnoracial identity, they are then asked their opinion on MENA related, POC related, and non-identity-related political questions. The control condition is a key aspect of this design because it serves as a baseline. Without this condition, it would be impossible to know whether the changes between the two treatments are caused by categorization affirmation or categorization threat.

Table 1, below, summarizes the major facets of design. The first column shows the control ($n = 142$). MENA respondents are not asked to self-categorize their identity until the end of the survey with “MENA” as an included option. The second column shows the categorization threat treatment ($n = 120$). Here, respondents are asked to self-categorize their identity immediately after consenting to the study, but “MENA” is not included as an option for individuals to self-categorize. The third column is the categorization affirmation treatment ($n = 138$). Respondents are asked to self-categorize their identity immediately after consenting to the study, and “MENA” is included as an option.

Outcome Measures

There are three categories of dependent variables. These include MENA identity-related questions, POC identity-related questions, and non-identity-related questions. The list of dependent variables, the question wording, and coding are provided in Section C.2, Tables C.1 through C.2 in the Supplementary Material. Drawing from extant literature and following hypotheses 1a and 1b, we should expect identity assertion to take shape on the questions related to the identity that was denied or affirmed. In this case, MENA identity is being made salient. Thus, to test whether MENA individuals are engaging in identity assertion, we should expect to observe changes in responses to MENA-related questions but not questions unrelated to MENA identity. Following from hypothesis 2, I also include questions that are related to POC identity more broadly. The extent to which categorization threat/affirmation influences responses to POC questions—and not questions unrelated to POC/MENA identity—reveals the scope of the treatment effect.

MENA respondents are asked questions about foreign affairs ranging from US intervention in Syria and Ukraine, support for Palestine, and opinions on

Trump’s travel ban. These questions focus mostly on issues that pertain to the MENA community. I also include a range of questions pertaining to intent to participate in politics from attending protests to boycotts to talking with family about politics and joining civic organizations. Questions about how likely respondents are to join organizations based on their ethnic or religious group are related to MENA identity whereas the remaining questions are not related to ethnoracial identities. Finally, I include evaluations of issue importance including civil rights for marginalized groups, COVID-19, the economy, immigration, national security, and social security. Questions about civil rights, immigration, and national security can be thought of as questions related to POC identity whereas the remaining questions are not identity-related. Finally, questions about the environment were preregistered as being non-identity-related. While they are presented in the results according to the preregistration plan, extant literature suggests the environment should be considered as related to POC identity. I discuss this further when conducting cross-study analyses.

All dichotomous variables have been recoded to be either 0 or 1. Ordinal and continuous variables have been rescaled from 0 to 1, with the lowest survey values (e.g., “strongly disagree”) corresponding to 0 and the highest survey values (e.g., “strongly agree”) corresponding to 1. Reverse coding is implemented when necessary to keep directions consistent. Given the number of dependent variables Section C.6.1, Tables C.24 to C.29 in the Supplementary Material provide analyses with p -values adjusted for multiple comparisons.¹² Substantive results remain robust to this adjustment with minor changes in significance, particularly for those findings reported at the $p < 0.1$ level.

Data and Methods

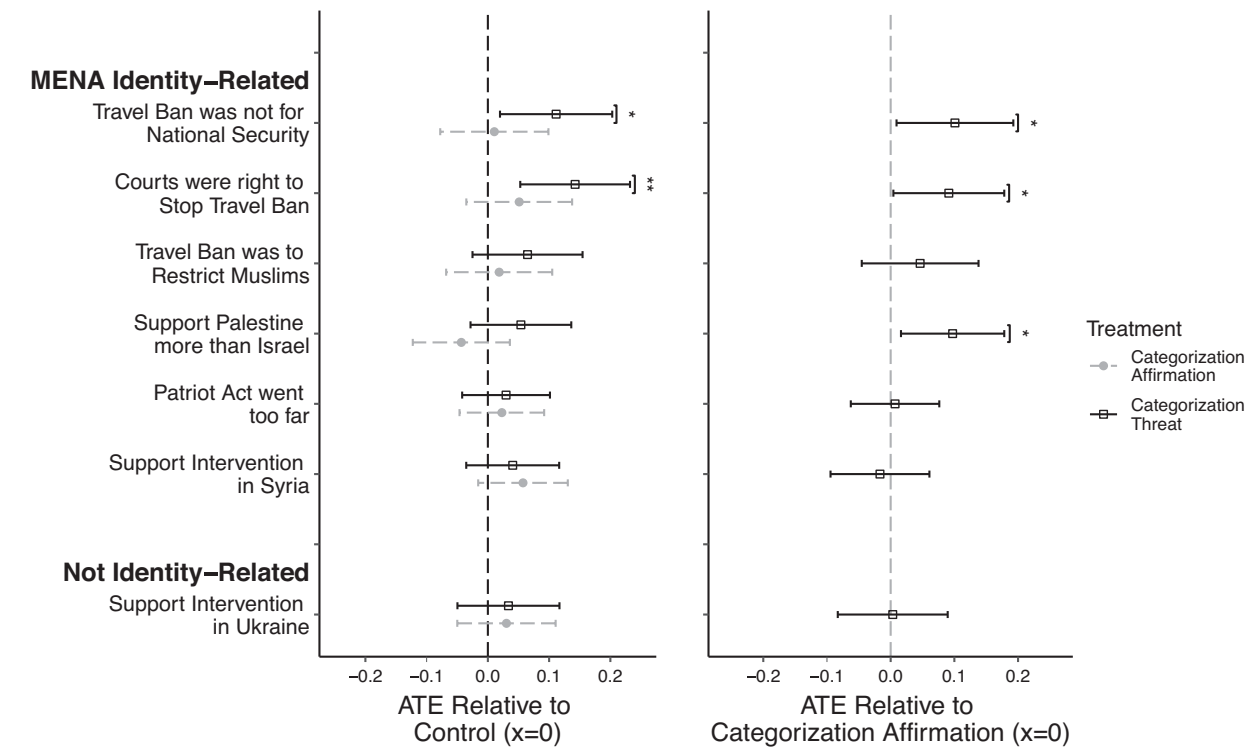
The target population for this survey experiment are respondents who have been pre-identified as being of Middle Eastern or North African descent. They were pre-selected based on ancestry but not whether they identify as “MENA” in order to make this a conservative test. To confirm the sample is of those of MENA descent, I also ask respondents to list their ancestry at the end of the survey. It is important to identify these individuals prior to invitation into the survey because asking about MENA identity or ancestry before the other outcomes of interest would leave no control condition and would make it impossible to induce categorization threat through the exclusion of the “MENA” category.

Most of the respondents (40%) indicated they were between 25 and 54, with a mean age of 42. The sample was skewed female with 52% of respondents identifying as women, 45% as men, and 3% as non-binary or other. The respondents were highly educated: 40% had a four-year college degree and 28% had a post-graduate degree. Moreover, 50% of respondents indicated they made \$60K or more in a year with 13% indicating they preferred not to share their income. Forty-two percent

TABLE 1. Study 1 Experimental Features

	Control condition	Categorization threat treatment	Categorization affirmation treatment
Identity asked before DVs?	No	Yes	Yes
“MENA” included?	Yes	No	Yes

¹² Also sometimes referred to as multiple hypotheses.

FIGURE 2. Study 1: Opinions on Foreign Affairs Issues

Note: MENA Respondents. + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

of respondents identified as first generation, and 30% indicated they were second-generation. This sample was ethnically and religiously diverse. Respondents were from a variety of ethnicities with the largest proportion indicating they were Arab (54%) or Persian (15%). The sample was also religiously diverse with Christian (22%), Muslim (27%), and Jewish (11%) respondents. The remainder of the sample indicated they were not religious (26%), but this does not necessarily mean that individuals did not grow up in religious households. (All demographic tables are presented in Section C.3, Tables C.4 through C.14 in the Supplementary Material.) Overall, the experimental conditions were balanced on key demographic characteristics (see Section C.4 Table C.15 in the Supplementary Material).

With three conditions, I have power (0.8) to detect an effect as small as Cohen's $\delta = 0.31$. With only 400 individuals across three treatments, this sample is too small to test for heterogeneity among respondents by important characteristics such as religion, ethnicity, generation, age, or socioeconomic status. Moreover, as there is no nationally available data regarding MENA individuals, there is no way to know what a truly representative sample of MENA individuals would look like to understand any heterogeneity.¹³ Because this design is

concerned with the impact of categorization threat and affirmation on expressed political opinions, I present the differences in average treatment effect across conditions.¹⁴

Results

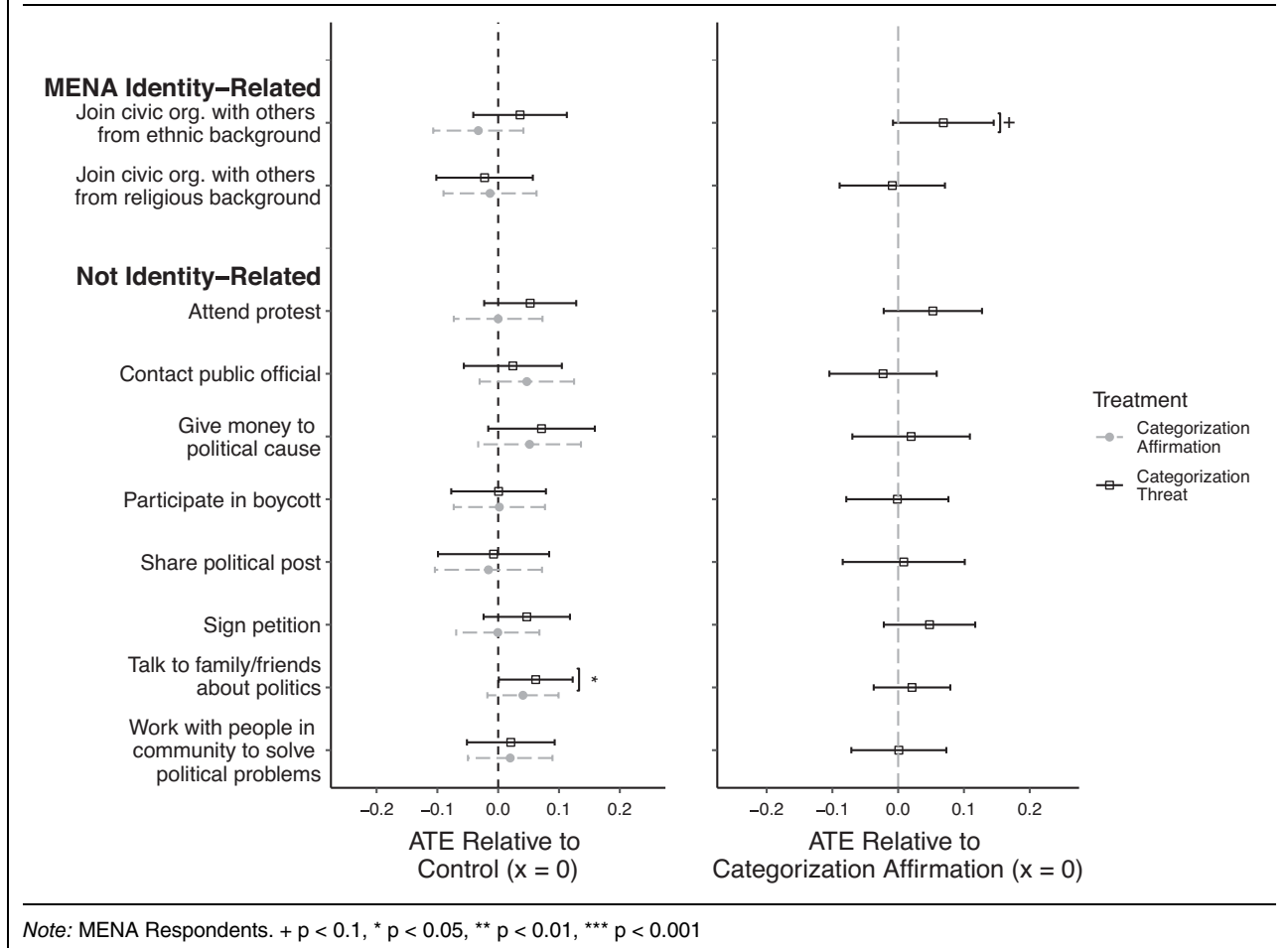
Figures 2–4, present changes in average treatment effects on the x -axis and dependent variables on the y -axis. The y -axis indicates which variables are identity-related and which are not. Each figure plots one of the dependent variable groups (e.g., Figure 2: foreign affairs; Figure 3: political participation; and Figure 4: issue importance).

There are two ways to test hypotheses 1a and 1b. Each treatment can be compared relative to the control condition or both treatments can also be compared relative to each other. Figures 2–4 present both. Panels on the left present the effect of categorization threat (solid black lines) and categorization affirmation (dashed gray lines) relative to the control condition (dashed black line at $x = 0$). Panels on the right present the effects of categorization threat (solid black lines) relative to categorization

¹³ The closest information we currently have comes from the American Community Survey based on ancestry alone, which would only

account for one type of representativeness. Without information about what a representative sample of MENA Americans entails, the results presented are without weights.

¹⁴ The average treatment effects, as opposed to Δ ATEs, are shown in Section C.5, Figures C.3 through C.5 in the Supplementary Material.

FIGURE 3. Study 1: Intention to Participate in Politics

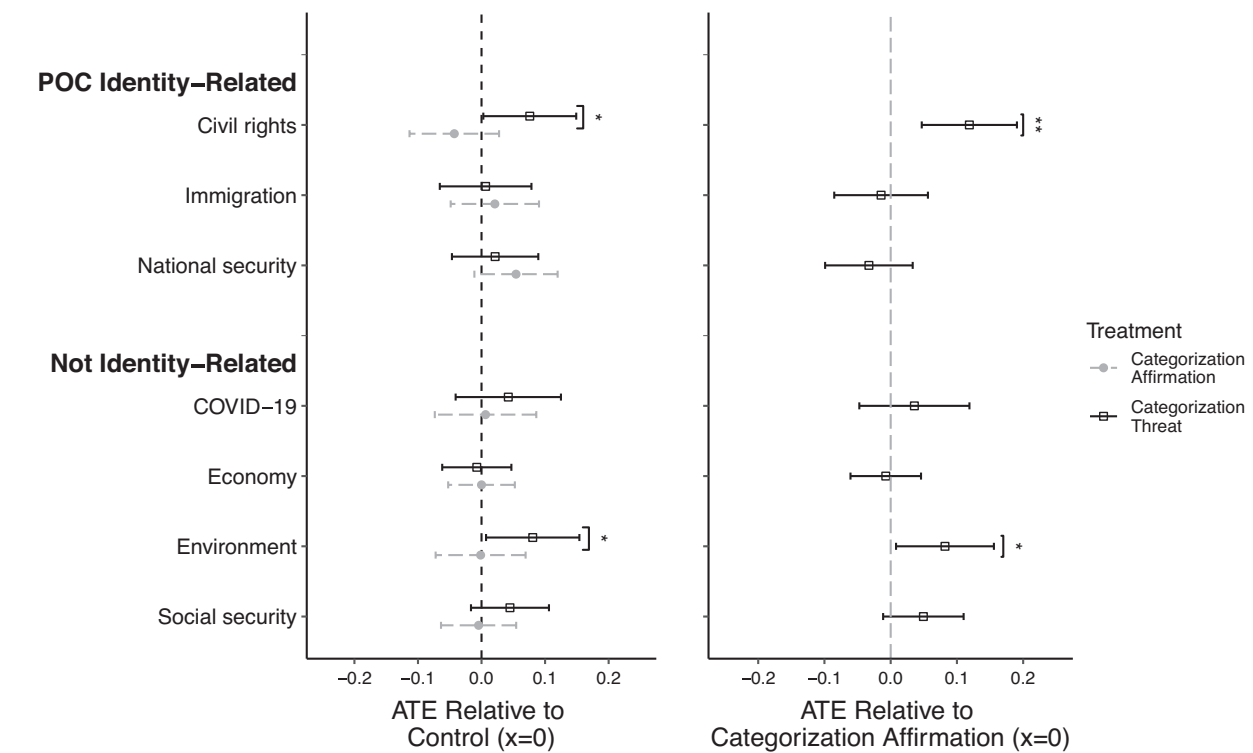
affirmation (dashed gray line at $x = 0$). Statistically significant results are indicated in each figure and represent the statistical significance of a given treatment relative to the respective baselines.

Figure 2 analyzes opinions on questions about foreign affairs.¹⁵ When MENA identity is affirmed through the inclusion of a “MENA” category, MENA participants respond to questions about foreign affairs in ways that are statistically equivalent to when MENA identity is not made salient. Across all seven foreign affairs dependent variables, there are no statistically significant results between category affirmation and control. On the other hand, there are differences relative to the control when MENA respondents experience categorization threat. MENA respondents experiencing categorization threat expressed that Trump’s travel ban was not for national security ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.111, p < 0.05$) and that they supported the court decision to strike down Trump’s travel ban ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.142, p < 0.01$) at higher rates relative to the control.

Next, I consider the differences between categorization threat and categorization affirmation. MENA individuals in the categorization threat condition expressed that Trump’s travel ban was not for national security ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.101, p < 0.05$), that the courts were right to block Trump’s travel ban ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.091, p < 0.05$), and that the US should support Palestinians ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.097, p < 0.05$) at higher rates relative to those in the categorization affirmation condition.

In order to test whether this change in average treatment effect is due to identity assertion, I also include a question that is not related to MENA identity—about US intervention in Ukraine. Here, there were no statistically significant differences when comparing either categorization threat or categorization affirmation to the control or compared to each other. This provides some support to suggest that categorization threat—but not categorization affirmation—leads MENA respondents to engage in identity assertion because these changes were seen on MENA-related issues and not on the issue unrelated to MENA identity. This provides moderate support for H1a, particularly given the subtlety of the experimental treatment and no support for H1b.

¹⁵ See Section C.6 Tables C.16 and C.17 in the Supplementary Material for linear models.

FIGURE 4. Study 1: Issue Importance

Note: MENA Respondents + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Figure 3 analyzes intent to participate in politics between categorization threat and affirmation relative to the control ($x = 0$; Section C.6, Table C.18 in the Supplementary Material) on the left and categorization threat relative to categorization affirmation ($x = 0$; Section C.6, Table C.19 in the Supplementary Material) on the right. Although these questions ask about intention to participate in politics, as opposed to measuring actual behavior, “intention to perform a behavior... is the closest cognitive antecedent of actual behavioral performance” (Ajzen and Fishbein 2005, 188). There were no statistically significant differences between responses among those in the categorization affirmation treatment relative to the control. However, relative to the control, those in the categorization threat condition were more likely to say they would talk to their friends and family about political issues ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.062$, $p < 0.05$). When testing the differences between the two treatments relative to one another, the statistical significance of talking to family about politics disappears; however, individuals in the categorization threat condition were more likely to say they would join a civic organization with members of their ethnic group ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.069$, $p < 0.1$). Although this finding is only statistically significant at the $p < 0.1$ level, this finding is in the expected direction (e.g., positive relative to categorization affirmation and related to MENA identity).

Whereas the questions on foreign affairs and participating in politics with one’s ethnic or religious group

are most directly linked to MENA identity, the following questions about how important various issues are to MENA respondents are related to POC identity, more generally. The questions related to broader identity include the importance of civil rights for marginalized groups, immigration, and national security. Questions not related to identity include the importance of COVID-19, the economy, the environment, and social security. This allows insight into the scope of the treatment effect on identity assertion.

Figure 4 analyzes how important different political issues are to MENA respondents between categorization threat and affirmation relative to the control ($x = 0$; Section C.6, Table C.20 in the Supplementary Material) on the left and categorization threat relative to categorization affirmation ($x = 0$; Section C.6, Table C.21 in the Supplementary Material) on the right. Consistent with the findings in Figures 2 and 3, categorization affirmation has no discernible treatment effect relative to the control. Those in the category affirmation treatment showed no statistically significant differences in how important they rated political issues relative to the control. On the other hand, there is continued evidence for identity assertions as a response to categorization threat. Those experiencing categorization threat report caring more about “civil rights for marginalized groups” ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.076$, $p < 0.05$) and the environment ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.081$, $p < 0.05$) relative to the control. These findings are more acute when comparing the effects of

identity threat relative to identity affirmation in the panel on the right. Once more, those experiencing categorization threat report caring more about civil rights for marginalized groups ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.119$, $p < 0.01$) and the environment ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.082$, $p < 0.05$) relative to the control.

Discussion

The overall results from this study suggest that when experiencing categorization affirmation, MENA individuals answer political questions in ways that are statistically equivalent to when they are not asked to self-categorize their identities at all (e.g., the control), thus failing to reject the null for hypothesis 1b. But when experiencing categorization threat, MENA individuals assert their identity relative to when they are not asked to self-categorize and relative to the categorization affirmation treatment. This lends moderate support for rejecting the null for hypothesis 1a. MENA respondents assert their identity most consistently when answering questions related to MENA identity but not when answering questions unrelated to MENA identity. This finding is also in line with previous research related to identity denial and identity assertion (Cheryan and Monin 2005; Barreto et al. 2010; Trujillo, Garcia, and Shelton 2015). Moreover, there is weak support for rejecting the null for hypothesis 2. Identity assertion may spillover to POC identity, not merely MENA identity. Interestingly, although immigration and national security are related to ethnoracial identities, only civil rights mentioned the phrase “for marginalized groups” in the question wording. Moreover, the environment was presented as unrelated to POC identity. However, as I discuss in the robustness analyses for Studies 1 and 2, there is a vast literature which suggests the environment *should* be thought of as an issue related to POC identity. As such, I believe the results in Figure 4 may be thought to include the environment as POC-related.

Study 2

Study 1 provides evidence that categorization threat leads MENA individuals to assert their identity by answering MENA and POC identity-related questions more strongly relative to non-identity-related questions. In order to ensure this pattern of findings is consistent, I conduct a follow-up study to replicate and expand Study 1. The aim of this study is to test whether similar findings emerge in a different sample at a different time, as well as updating some of the dependent variable questions.

Study 2 follows the same experimental flow as the two treatments in Study 1 displayed Figure 1 but without a control condition. Individuals pre-identified as being “MENA” are randomly assigned into one of two conditions. In both conditions, MENA respondents are asked to self-categorize their ethnoracial identity immediately after consenting to be a part of the study. In the categorization threat condition, “MENA” is not included as an option, whereas it is included in the

categorization affirmation condition. Additionally, unlike in Study 1, individuals were not given the option to select “some other race” in either condition. Although the experimental treatment is still subtle, removing the option to self-categorize as “some other race” for those in the categorization threat condition is a slightly stronger treatment relative to Study 1.

Outcome Measures

Between Studies 1 and 2, some dependent variables have remained the same, whereas others have been changed to further assess the scope of categorization threat on identity assertion. Dependent variable questions can be found in Section C.2, Tables C.1 through C.3 in the Supplementary Material. Some of these questions are identity-related, whereas others are non-identity-related. Moreover, within the identity-related questions, some are directly MENA-related, whereas others relate to ethnoracial minorities writ large. Of the specific MENA-related questions, both studies ask about (1) whether Trump’s “Muslim Ban” was issued due to concerns about national security; (2) questions regarding the Palestinian–Israeli conflict; (3) the importance of civil rights for marginalized groups; (4) whether respondents intend on boycotting a company; and (5) whether they would join a civic organization with individuals in their ethnic group to solve a problem in their community. The non-MENA-related questions that are similar across studies include (6) questions regarding the Ukrainian–Russian conflict; (7) the importance of the environment; (8) the importance of social security; and (9) whether respondents intend on speaking with their family about politics. Additional questions included whether they believe President Trump may try to reimpose the travel ban, opinions on tariffs on China, opinions on Joe Biden rejoining the Paris Climate Change Agreement, the importance of surveillance of racial minorities, and the importance of providing ballots in multiple languages. Again, the environmental issues, including the Paris Climate Agreement, are presented as non-identity-related, in line with preregistration, but may be thought of as POC-identity related (discussed in detail during cross-study analyses).

All dichotomous variables have been recoded to be from 0 to 1. Both ordinal and continuous variables have been rescaled from 0 to 1 continuous scale, with the lowest survey values (e.g., “strongly disagree”) corresponding to 0 and the highest survey values (e.g., “strongly agree”) corresponding to 1 and reverse coded when necessary for consistency in direction.¹⁶ Again, due to the number of outcome variables, adjustments for multiple comparisons can be found in Section D.7.1, Tables D.46–D.48 in the Supplementary Material.

In line with Study 1, I find support that categorization threat leads to identity assertion among MENA respondents. This assertion was observed via response

¹⁶ All corresponding linear models can be found in Section D.7, Tables D.43 to D.45 with in the Supplementary Material.

substitution on questions related to MENA identity but not on questions unrelated to MENA identity. Again, there is weaker support that this assertion extends to POC related-identity assertion.

Data and Methods

As in Study 1, I could not advertise that this study is about MENA identity, because that would be affirming the very identity the categorization threat treatment seeks to deny. Thus, I need to only administer this study to individuals who are pre-identified as being of MENA descent. To avoid resampling individuals who had already taken this study, I opted for Prolific, which has a filter for individuals who have indicated they are “Middle Eastern.”¹⁷

This study was fielded from October 17, 2024, through January 6, 2025, for a total of 297 eligible responses.¹⁸ With two conditions, I have power (0.8) to detect an effect size as small as Cohen's $d = 0.33$. As in Study 1, because there are no nationally representative data on MENA individuals, it is currently not possible to assess how closely this sample aligns with a national sample of MENA Americans across demographic characteristics such as religion, generation, age, or socioeconomic status. Sample demographics are available in Section D.3, Tables D.33 through D.40 in the Supplementary Material and are briefly summarized here. The sample had more women (56%) relative to men (43%) (with 1% identifying as non-binary). A majority of the sample were individuals 44 years or younger (88%). Nearly half of the sample had received a four-year college degree (46%) with an additional quarter of the sample (25%) receiving a post-graduate degree of some sort. One third of the sample reported household income as under \$60,000 (33%) with the remainder indicating their household income was \$60,000 or above. The sample skewed ideologically liberal with 45% indicating they were either “somewhat” or “very liberal” and 33% indicating they were moderate. Similarly, about 40% of the sample indicated they were Democrats of some strength, and 40% indicated they were Independent. The remainder

identified as Republican. A majority of the respondents were second generation with about 74% indicating they were born in the US. Of these individuals, 87% indicated that either one or both of their parents were not born in the US. Finally, I also asked about the religion that respondents practiced or that was practiced in their household while growing up.¹⁹ The sample was religiously diverse with Christian (28%), Muslim (39%), and Jewish (6%) respondents. Approximately 16% of respondents indicated that they were not religious, with the remainder indicating other religions. Overall, the experimental conditions balanced on key demographic characteristics (see Section D.4 Table D.42 in the Supplementary Material).

Results

All figures present the difference in average treatment effects between the two conditions.²⁰ Figure 5 presents the results of categorization threat on opinions on foreign affairs relative to categorization affirmation (plotted at $x = 0$). As with Study 1, some issues are specifically MENA-related, such as questions about Trump's “Muslim Ban,” as well as questions related to Israeli and Palestinian affairs. Questions that were not related to identity included opinions on involvement in the conflict between Russia and Ukraine, support for rejoining the Paris Climate Agreement, and support for increasing tariffs on China.

When respondents experienced categorization threat, they indicated that Trump's travel ban was not for national security ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.074$, $p < 0.1$), expressed worry that Trump will reimpose the travel ban ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.096$, $p < 0.05$) and that Israel's military response in Gaza has been excessive ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.065$, $p < 0.05$) at levels higher than respondents in the categorization affirmation condition.

On the other hand, there were no statistically significant differences between experimental conditions and opinions on increasing tariffs on China or interference in the conflict between Russia and Ukraine. However, there was a statistically significant difference between support for President Biden's decision to rejoin the Paris Climate Agreement ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.078$, $p < 0.05$). Those in the categorization threat condition expressed more support for this decision relative to those in the categorization affirmation condition.

Between Study 1 and Study 2, I repeated questions related to Trump's Muslim ban, Israel and Palestine, and Russia and Ukraine. The statistical significance and insignificance were consistent across the two studies. MENA identity-related questions about the travel ban and Israel and Palestine were statistically significant and the non-identity-related question about Russia and Ukraine was insignificant.

¹⁷ While “Middle Eastern” is not the same as “Middle Eastern and North African,” the terms are often used interchangeably. I had a diverse set of individuals who indicated they had ancestry in the Middle East and North Africa in this sample further suggesting that North Africans understand the colloquial usage of “Middle Eastern” to refer to North Africans, as well. Because extant research and supplementary findings from Study 1 show that MENA individuals prefer to self-categorize as such, it is internally valid to select respondents who already self-categorize as “Middle Eastern” on their Prolific profiles. This would only be a concern if I was testing whether MENA individuals self-categorize as such, essentially selecting on the dependent variable; however, the aim of this study is to test the political consequences of categorization threat.

¹⁸ In line with my preregistered analysis plan, I removed individuals who were likely inattentive as they took two standard deviations ($2\sigma = 947.51$) above or below the mean duration in seconds ($\bar{x} = 518.84$) to complete the survey. This meant 9 individuals who took 24.44 minutes or longer to complete a 7–10 minute survey.

¹⁹ This is a deviation from how the question was asked in Study 1. In Study 1, I only asked about currently practiced religion, not about their household religion growing up.

²⁰ Full ATEs (as opposed to Δ ATEs can be found in Section D.6 in the Supplementary Material).

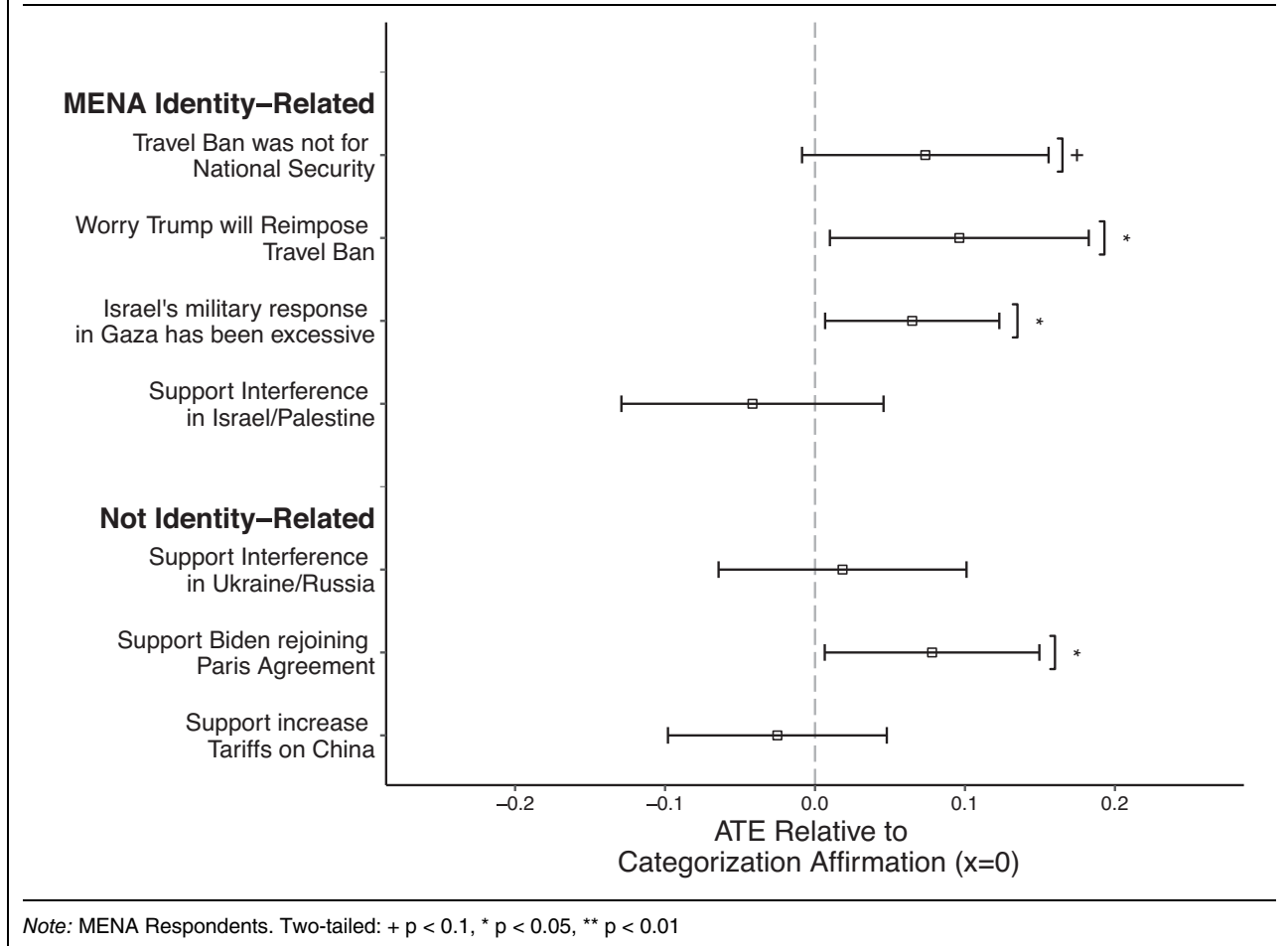
FIGURE 5. Study 2: Opinions on Foreign Affairs

Figure 6 presents differences in expressed opinions on intention to participate in various political activities over the next 12 months. Drawing from the results in Study 1, I include two MENA identity-related questions and one non-identity-related question. The MENA identity-related questions include whether respondents intend to join a civic organization with other members of their ethnic group and whether they intend to participate in a boycott or buycott. Whereas boycotts and buycotts were not MENA-related issues when Study 1 was administered, they were when Study 2 was administered.²¹ The non-identity-related question relates to whether they plan to talk with their family and friends about politics. I determined this grouping by assessing what respondents shared they were thinking about when answering the political participation questions in open-ended responses.

Relative to respondents in the categorization affirmation condition, those in the categorization threat condition were more likely to say that they intend to participate

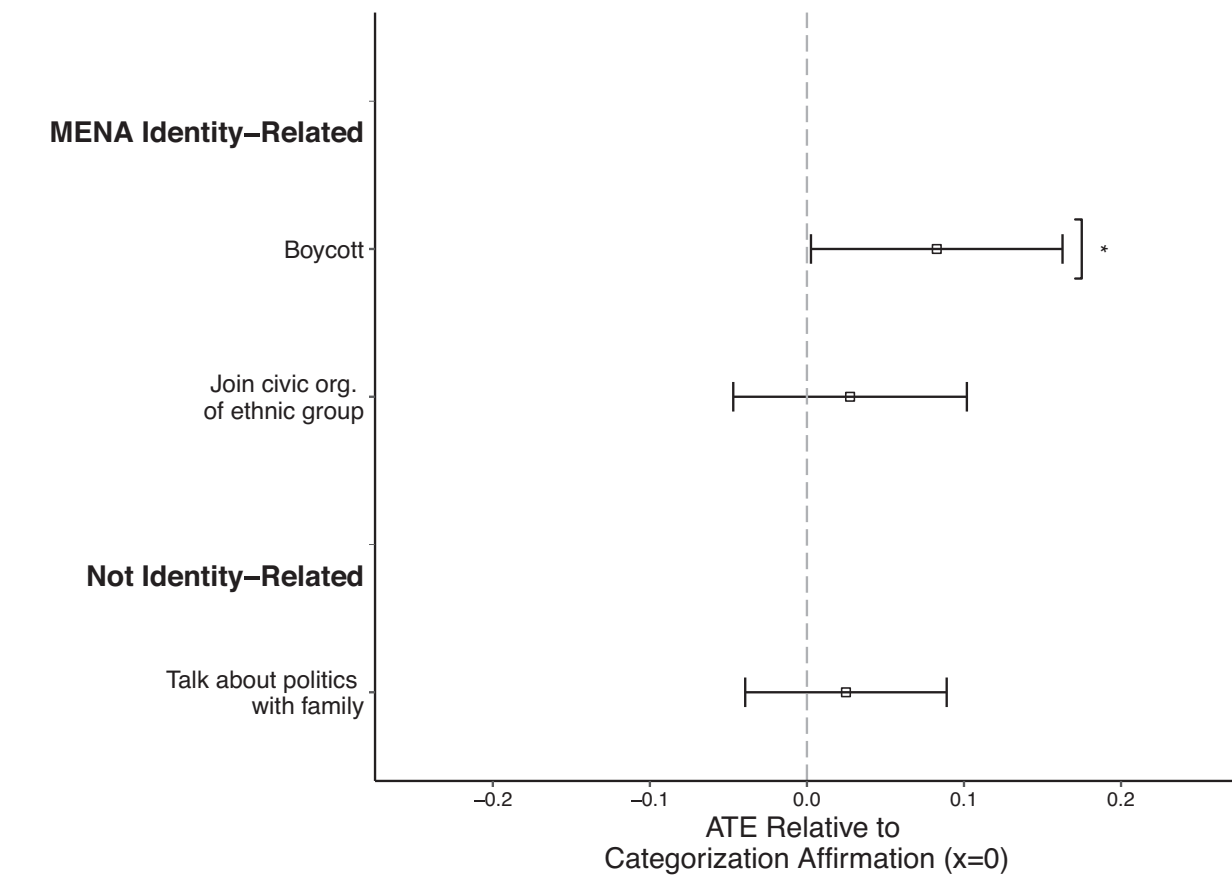
in a boycott or buycott ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.083, p < 0.05$). However, the other two questions were statistically insignificant.

Finally, Figure 7 presented the differences in expressed opinions on how important different political issues are relative to categorization affirmation ($x = 0$). Again, these questions are designed to capture POC identity broadly, as opposed to MENA identity, specifically. Thus, some of these questions are POC identity-related whereas others are not identity-related. The importance of decreasing surveillance on racial minorities, civil rights for marginalized groups, affirmative action for racial minorities, and the availability of multilingual ballots²² are all POC identity-related. The importance of social security for the elderly, rural infrastructure, curbing inflation on grocery prices, and the environment were not identity-related.

Overall, there is little support indicating that categorization threat extends to the broader category of POC identity. Of the POC identity-related issues, the availability of multilingual ballots was more important for

²¹ Open-ended responses following all three political participation questions indicated that boycotting was thought of as a MENA-related political participation. Section D.5 of the Supplementary Material discusses this decision and open-ended responses in depth.

²² These responses are restricted to individuals who took the survey before the presidential election on November 6, 2024, when this issue would be relevant and salient. The effects are non-significant for after the election.

FIGURE 6. Study 2: Intention to Participate in Politics

Note: MENA Respondents. Two-tailed: + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$

those in the categorization threat condition ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.094$, $p < 0.1$) relative to the categorization affirmation condition. However, no other POC identity-related issues were statistically distinguishable from responses in the categorization affirmation treatment.

One surprising finding consistent with findings in Study 1, is that individuals in the categorization threat condition listed the environment as more important ($\Delta\bar{x} = 0.064$, $p < 0.05$) relative to the categorization affirmation condition. This is also consistent with the earlier findings in this study that indicated those in the categorization threat condition were more likely to say they supported Biden rejoining the Paris Climate Agreement. Across the two studies, issues related to the environment were asked a total of three times, and all three were statistically significant. As mentioned in Study 1, Figure 4, I preregistered environmental issues as unrelated to identity. However, in the section below, I include a discussion of why, given a host of existing scientific evidence, the environment *should be* considered POC identity-related.

Discussion

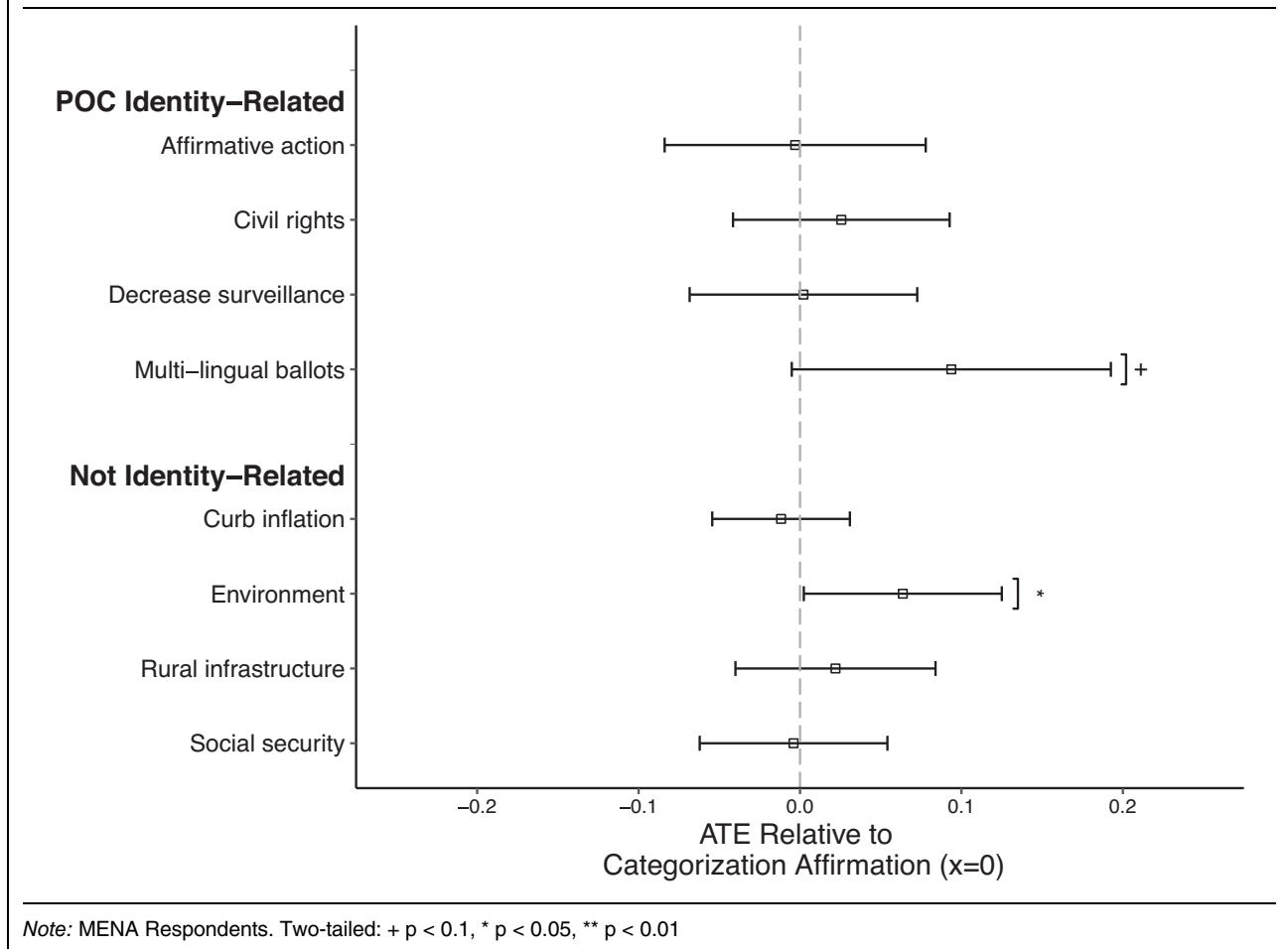
The results from Study 1 and 2 both indicated support for hypothesis 1a and weak support for hypothesis 2. As

with Study 1, this study denied MENA identity by not providing “MENA” as an option for self-categorization among MENA American respondents, inducing categorization threat. This threat leads MENA individuals to assert their identity in other ways while answering the remainder of the survey.

Cross-Study Analyses

Table 2 provides a summary of the results for the two studies. Across two studies, 14 dependent variables related to MENA identity (eight in Study 1 and six in Study 2). Out of these 14, eight were statistically significant (four in each study) or a rate of 57%. This success rate is stark given the extreme subtlety of the treatment.

There is mixed support to suggest that this treatment had an impact on POC identity assertion, not merely MENA identity assertion. However, the evidence to support this finding is stronger when deviating from my preregistered hypotheses and drawing on literature related to concern for the environment among people of color. Although I preregistered concern for the environment as a non-identity-related issue, I believe it should be considered POC identity-related. For one,

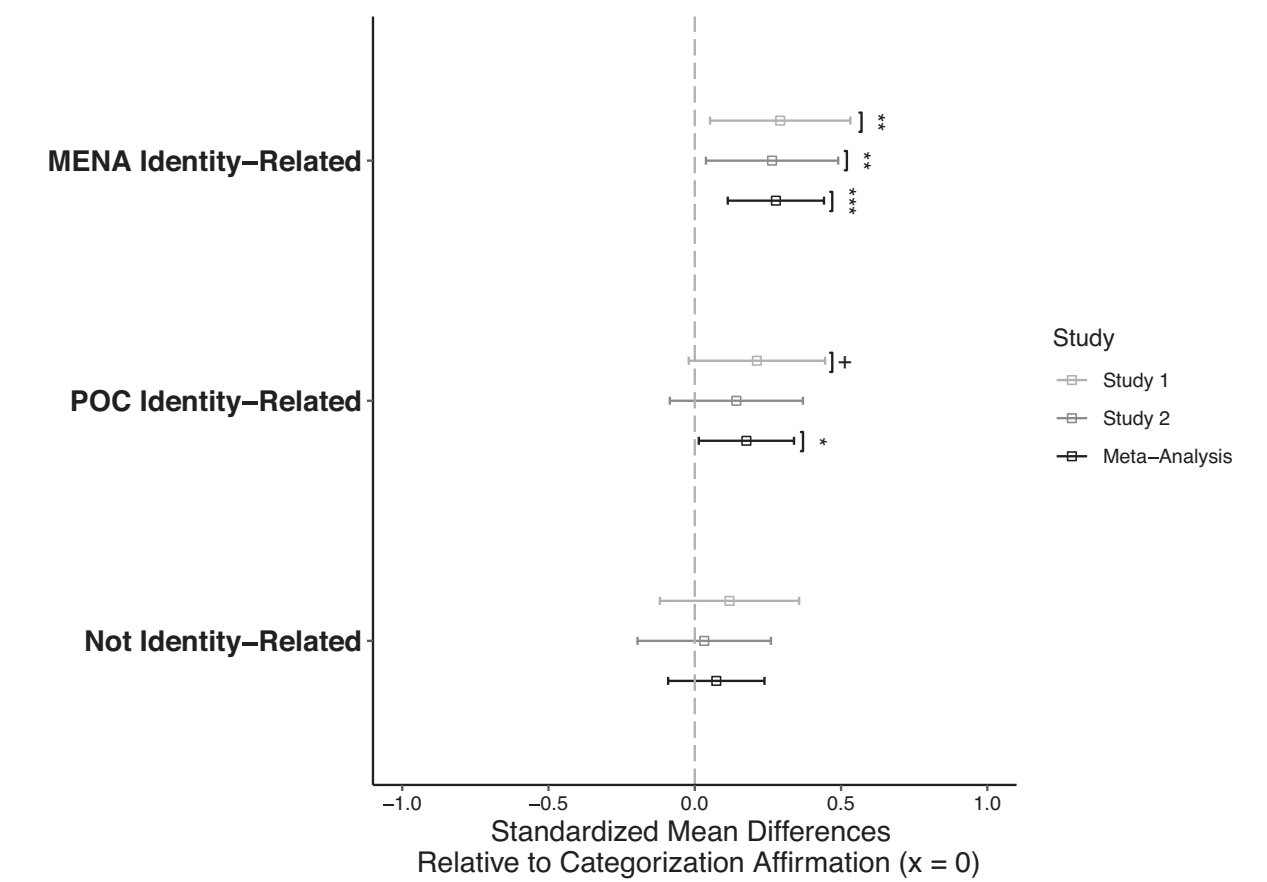
FIGURE 7. Study 2: Issue Importance**TABLE 2. Studies 1 and 2 Summary of Results**

	MENA identity-related	POC identity-related	Not identity-related
Study 1	4 of 8	2 of 4	1 of 12
Study 2	4 of 6	3 of 6	0 of 6
Cross-study totals	8 of 14 (57%)	5 of 10 (50%)	1 of 18 (6%)

research shows that the environment is often thought to be an issue that White Americans care about more than non-White Americans; however, multiple studies have found that people of color care just as much if not more, about the environment than White Americans (Jones 1998; Jones and Rainey 2006; Lazri and Konisky 2019; Li 2021; McCright and Dunlap 2011; Noe and Snow 1990; Pearson et al. 2018; Song et al. 2020). And this concern is not a new phenomenon. For instance, Lazri and Konisky (2019) use nationally representative data from Gallup across 15 years to show that people of color are *more* concerned about issues of environmental justice relative to White Americans. Most Americans underestimate how

concerned racial and ethnic minorities are about the environment, *including other racial and ethnic minorities themselves* (Pearson et al. 2018). Importantly, Li (2021) finds that “group consciousness plays an exceptionally important role for racial minorities, and it accounts for much of racial minorities’ higher levels of concern and participatory intentions compared with Whites.” Li (2021) empirically shows that *group consciousness* is the primary mechanism behind the concern people of color have for the environment. Finally, supplementary analyses using the 2020 CMPS also show an association between MENA identity importance and concern for the environment but not for other measures I indicated were not-identity-related, such as the economy (see Section F, Table F.64 in the Supplementary Material). The existing literature, as well as the consistency of the findings related to the environment in Studies 1 and 2, suggests that the environment should not necessarily be thought of as an issue unrelated to POC identity.

This would mean that across both experiments there were a total of ten POC identity-related outcomes (four in Study 1 and six in Study 2). Of these ten, five were statistically significant (two in Study 1 and three in Study 2). On the other hand, out of 18 non-MENA-

FIGURE 8. Overall Experimental Results

Note: MENA Respondents. + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

related outcomes (12 in Study 1 and six in Study 2), only one was statistically significant (in Study 1). Thus, categorization threat led to identity assertion in the form of response substitution 57% of the time for MENA-related questions, 50% of the time for POC identity-related questions, and 6% of the time for non-identity-related questions. These rates of success provide additional support to reject the null of hypotheses 1a and 2; however, they are only descriptive.

To assess the *overall* effect of categorization threat across the two studies, I present cross-study meta-analytics between an index of MENA identity-related, POC identity-related questions, and non-identity-related questions for Studies 1 and 2 in Figure 8.²³ First, I create three indexed variables for each study. One indexed item includes all MENA identity-related questions, one includes all POC identity-related questions, and the last includes all non-identity-related questions.²⁴ I then

transform these indexes into standardized means and plot each dependent variable index for each study separately, in gray. In Study 1, we see that the index of MENA-related items is statistically significantly different for those in the categorization threat condition relative to categorization affirmation ($\bar{z} = 0.292$, $p < 0.05$), as is the difference for POC identity-related items ($\bar{z} = 0.212$, $p < 0.1$), but not for non-identity-related questions ($\bar{z} = 0.108$, $p = 0.374$). In Study 2, respondents in the categorization threat condition answered MENA-related items more strongly relative to categorization affirmation ($\bar{z} = 0.264$, $p < 0.05$), but not for either POC identity-related ($\bar{z} = 0.142$, $p = 0.222$) or non-identity-related questions ($\bar{z} = 0.032$, $p = 0.782$).

In addition to testing the indices for each dependent variable grouping in each study, I conduct meta-analytic tests across these studies. The standardized mean difference for each is plotted in black in Figure 8. The standardized mean difference across both studies is statistically significant for categorization threat relative to

²³ Although meta-analyses typically refer to analyses on a number of studies, it is still appropriate to refer to analyses of two (or more) studies as meta-analytic tests.

²⁴ Some of these groupings deviate from preregistration. Section E.4 of the Supplementary Material discusses these deviations in detail and provides supplementary analyses aligning with preregistration (for

example, see Section E.3, Figures E.11 and E.12 in the Supplementary Material). While the results for H1a remain consistent, coding all POC-related questions as not identity-related removes some nuance to the scope of the effect that I found important to consider in H2.

categorization affirmation ($\bar{z} = 0.277$, $p < 0.001$) for MENA-related questions and also for POC identity-related questions ($\bar{z} = 0.176$, $p < 0.05$) but statistically insignificant for non-identity-related questions ($\bar{z} = 0.069$, $p = 0.414$).²⁵ Ultimately, this suggests that categorization threat among MENA respondents influences not only the assertion of *MENA* identity but POC identity more broadly defined. Thus, I reject the null for both hypotheses 1a and 2.²⁶

While the rate of difference between treatment and control across relevant dependent variables may seem small, these results underscore that the sample sizes of the studies are substantially lower relative to most conventional survey experiments *and* that this experimental treatment was exceptionally conservative. The only difference between these treatments was that in one, “MENA” was available for individuals to self-categorize, and in the other treatment it was absent. Moreover, the subtlety of this treatment is something that MENA individuals experience regularly since most forms do not include “MENA.” This means that there is a potential for habituation to categorization threat. Yet these results are still observed. Although the OMB announced in 2024 that “MENA” is to be added as a distinct category, these changes are unlikely to take shape widely in American society until after the 2030 Census when “MENA” is officially included. This means that for MENA Americans categorization threat is likely to be a continued experience.

Study 3: In-Depth Interviews

When MENA individuals are not given the opportunity to self-categorize their identity, are they really experiencing categorization threat? While the experimental results show that the lack of a MENA category option changes how MENA individuals respond to questions about politics related to MENA and POC identities, is this because they experienced categorization threat? To gain a sense of whether the lack of a MENA category is perceived as categorization threat, I include evidence from in-depth interviews. Between 2022 and 2025, I conducted 17 in-depth, semi-structured interviews with MENA individuals in the US, reaching saturation.²⁷ The goal of these interviews is not generalizability, but to provide construct validity that MENA individuals’ identities are made salient when

experiencing categorization threat and that they react to this threat by engaging in response substitution to assert their MENA identity. In the case of self-categorization, some MENA individuals deliberately shift their responses to increase the distance from being “White” and/or allow for more proximity to the “MENA” category.

Interviewees and Method

Interviewees were recruited through both convenience and snowball sampling techniques. In addition to recruiting from my networks, I cold-recruited individuals from the D.C. metropolitan area, individuals on social media, and individuals in MENA-related identity groups on college campuses. As a part of the snowballing technique, I also asked individuals to connect me with anyone else in their networks who would be willing to speak with me. I aimed to interview MENA individuals from different racial, ethnic, religious, generational, and age ranges. Each participant filled out a survey which included demographic questionnaires and then participated in an interview lasting anywhere from 45 to 60 minutes. They received \$25 for their participation (guiding interview questions can be found in Section G.1 of the Supplementary Material). Although the interviews were recorded, I also took handwritten notes. After the interviews, I transcribed the recordings verbatim and coded them in NVivo.

After I ask the interviewees to discuss their backgrounds (e.g., ethnoracial and country of ancestry), I ask them about the federal categorization of MENA Americans: “Some people are unaware of this but Middle Eastern, North African, and Arab Americans are/were legally categorized in the US as White. What does this mean to you?” From here, interviewees discussed their relationship with the “MENA” category and their reactions when “MENA” is not given as an option with the understanding that the legal category is “White,” instead. I do not directly ask about categorization threat or response substitution. These themes emerged naturally from the prompt.

Section G.2, Table G.67 in the Supplementary Material, includes a list of the descriptive characteristics of the interview participants and is briefly summarized as follows. Most of the interviewees are women. The interviewees are of different age ranges: three are a part of Gen Z, eight are a part of the Millennial cohort, four are Gen X, and two are Boomers. Moreover, their immigration histories differ; six are first-generation, seven are second-generation, and three are Generation 1.5 because they moved to the US at a young age. These interviewees are from different countries of origin and are religiously and ethnically diverse. English was not the first language for half of the interviewees.

²⁵ The results were identical between the common and random effects models. Moreover, the test for heterogeneity between studies was not statistically significant in any test.

²⁶ As an additional test of plausibility related to the hypothesized relationship between the treatment and the affected outcomes (e.g., identity-related versus not-identity-related), I include supplementary analyses using the CMPS to gauge whether there is an association between MENA identity importance and reported attitudes and behaviors related to political issues and political participation on questions that are similar to the dependent variables in Studies 1 and 2. These results are available in Section F, Tables F.63 and F.64 in the Supplementary Material. Overall, I find parity between the outcomes associated with an increase in MENA identity importance and the outcomes which were both statistically significant and insignificant in Studies 1 and 2.

²⁷ The number of interviews should not be thought of in statistical terms but in conceptual terms. To determine the number of interviews needed, researchers look for saturation—when new themes cease to arise. “Saturation has, in fact, become the gold standard by which purposive sample sizes are determined,” (Guest, Bunce, and Johnson 2006, 60) and has been found to occur within the first 12 interviews and as early as six.

Results

Many interviewees discussed their thought process behind why they shifted their response options when “MENA” was not available. Not only did many MENA individuals express frustration when “MENA” is not given as an ethnoracial category option, they spoke about using their responses on the survey to assert their identity. These comments were largely unprompted, as well. This provides insights into the mechanism at play in Studies 1 and 2. Moreover, I find additional insight into why MENA individuals engage in this behavior. For many, they wish to signal proximity to “MENA” identity and distance themselves from their designation as “White.”

Qamar, a Libyan Amazigh woman, expressed her frustration with the lack of a “MENA” category. To her, the absence of a category is “an effort [by the Federal Government] to just dilute who we are... to just suppress who we are.” She added that although she used to feel a sense of validation in the fact that the US federal government categorized MENA individuals as “White,” the racialization she experienced as a North African in the US has made her reassess her ethnoracial category.

It used to be like, Look, look! The federal government [categorizes] me as “White.” I am White! That was then... And then it was, Wait, I’m not White. I’m not seen as White. I’m certainly not treated as White, but yet the federal government continues to dilute my identity and make me pick “White.” I never pick “White” nowadays anymore. I will pick “Other,” or I will not answer the question anymore.

For Qamar, having the legal designation as “White” is not something she can bring herself to self-categorize with. This means that she is acutely aware that when the option to self-categorize as “MENA” is absent, she is *supposed to* self-categorize as “White.” Yet, she deliberately decides to either skip the question or select “Other” instead.

Grace, a Palestinian Christian woman, expressed similar sentiments. She says that she is very aware that until the OMB updated their racial categories, MENA individuals were legally categorized as “White.” She says that being categorized as “White” makes her feel that MENA Americans “are an invisible race and ethnicity.” “I don’t like it,” she continues. Partly as a response to being made to feel invisible, she says that when she is asked about her race and ethnicity, she will select “Other” or she will completely opt out of responding to that question altogether. She says,

I only [skip answering the race question if] they don’t give me a chance to say “Other,” or “Middle Eastern.” If “Middle Eastern” [is an option], I would fill it out 100% of the time.

Like Qamar, even though her official category is available for her to self-categorize (e.g., “White”), she opts to select “Other” and write in “Middle Eastern.” Doing so allows her to increase her proximity to MENA identity and decrease her proximity to White identity. Writing in

“Middle Eastern” is the next best option for Grace. She says if “Other” is not an option, she will skip the question entirely. Although skipping the question does not allow her to assert a “MENA” identity, it does still allow her to distance herself from the “White” category. When confronted with categorization threat on a survey, Grace and Qamar change how they respond to the survey questions.

Arman, an Iranian Armenian man, expressed a similar sentiment to Grace and Qamar but with added nuance. Like Grace and Qamar, he says that he will either select “Other” or he will simply skip the question entirely. However, he also discusses his reaction when he sees that forms include “MENA” as explicitly situated within the “White” category:

I’ve seen more recent forms that have started making that distinction [between “White” and “MENA”], which is nice to see. But if I see that on a form, and it’s just “White,” and it includes “Middle Eastern” [within “White”], I won’t answer it. I will put “Other,” because I think that’s a ridiculous way to classify people from that region.

However, not all interviewees skipped the question when it was set up in that manner. Erum, a young Egyptian woman said:

I’ve never conformed to clicking “Caucasian” on any forms. I’ll always, do “Other,” and I’ll write, “Middle Eastern, North African,” because it’s just— I don’t even have any words. There’s so many things that are wrong with the way government systems in the US identify people... I’ve never conformed to it. I’ve never felt like I need to abide by that. I’m not Caucasian. I’m not grouped into that category. I don’t look Caucasian. I don’t have the privilege of being Caucasian.

However, she has said that when a form is set up in a way where her identity is under “Caucasian,” she will self-categorize as that so that she will be able to self-categorize as “Egyptian.”

[My university] applications are really annoying, though, because they have you put... “Caucasian,” and then they had a breakdown menu where you could choose the countries that you were from. I chose “Caucasian,” but then I chose Egypt.

Thus, for some MENA individuals, categorization threat is not merely about the absence of a “MENA” category. For Arman, MENA individuals should be categorized as a distinct ethnoracial group, not one subsumed under “White.” This means that even if “MENA” is explicitly included, he will purposefully not self-categorize as such if “MENA” is placed within the “White” category. Erum, on the other hand, feels annoyed but nevertheless does self-categorize as “White” only so that she can identify herself as being “Egyptian.” Otherwise, she selects “Other.” Even though there are some variations in how people like Arman or Erum decide to navigate the different ways forms organize ethnoracial identities, it is very clear that they both wish to self-categorize as “MENA” and

will shift their responses when they are not able to do so.

But are individuals thinking about their reactions to categorization threat as an assertion of their identity? Simona says,

If it's an option, I'm putting "Other," because I definitely feel like "White" does not capture how I identify. It feels like one way of me trying to shift things [is] by giving that feedback [on] the form.

Although Simona knows she is supposed to select "White," she says she sees herself as providing feedback to those who will eventually look through and analyze the data. There is a hope that by selecting "Other" and writing in "Middle Eastern," the people administering the survey will decide to add it as a category in the future.

Discussion

There was a consistent theme that emerged from these interviews. When interviewees were unable to self-categorize as "MENA," many felt a sense of miscategorization and identity denial. This theme provides construct validity that the experimental treatments without a "MENA" category induced categorization threat. When "MENA" is not available, interviewees shared that they preferred not to self-categorize as "White," instead often selecting "Other," or even skipping the question altogether. In fact, extant research provides quantitative evidence of this, as well. When MENA individuals are unable to self-categorize as such, it is not uncommon for them to self-categorize as "Some other race" instead of as "White" (d'Urso 2022; Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022; Mathews et al. 2017; see Section B, Table B.1 in the Supplementary Material). Selecting "Other," or even skipping the question, is a deliberate choice when confronted with the experience of categorization threat. This gives further insights into response substitution as a means to assert one's identity. Instead of selecting their (formerly) legally-defined category, MENA individuals substitute their response choice to an option that will, at the very least, distance themselves from the identity they have been miscategorized into. These interviews helped to provide additional validity for the claims drawn from the experimental studies.

CONCLUSION

People often rely on their identity groups to seek political representation. In turn, representative democracies aim to be responsive to their citizens. However, it is sometimes the case that the labels individuals use to identify themselves do not align with institutionally recognized categories. Multi-ethnoracial individuals experienced this before they were allowed to select more than one ethnoracial category on the 2000 U.S. Census (Davenport 2018; Masuoka 2017; Sanchez 2010; Townsend, Markus, and Bergsieker 2009). Today, groups such as Native Hawaiians (Phan and Lee 2022), Afro-Caribbeans (McPherson

2017; Smith 2020; Waters 2009), and transgender individuals (Fath and Proudfoot 2024), among other groups, commonly face the juxtaposition of having an identity without always being able to represent that identity on forms or official documents.²⁸ This also includes MENA Americans.

MENA Americans are a politically salient group who have experienced the mismatch of identity categorization. From 1977 to 2024, MENA individuals were legally categorized as "White" in the US despite being racialized as non-White for much of that time (Beydoun 2013; d'Urso and Bonilla 2023; d'Urso 2022; 2024; Gualtieri 2009; Maghbouleh 2017; 2025; Naber 2000). Due to this racialization, many MENA individuals do not wish to be labeled as "White." When MENA Americans are given the opportunity to self-categorize as "MENA," they will do so, forgoing the category "White" (d'Urso 2022; Mathews et al. 2017; Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022; also, Section B, Figure B.1 in the Supplementary Material). Moreover, MENA individuals are a highly politicized and visible group, often profiled and surveilled in ways that solidify their non-White racial position in the US despite being categorized as "White" for nearly 50 years (Abdelkarim 2003; d'Urso 2022; Garner and Selod 2015; Hassan 2002; Hobbs and Lajevardi 2019; Ibish and Stewart 2003; Maghbouleh 2017; 2025; Naber 2000; Shaheen 2003). Even so, they are often unable to self-categorize their identity given most forms do not include "MENA" as a separate ethnoracial response option. Although the OMB has announced changes to the federal racial categories to include "MENA," absent a census, reliable survey information on MENA Americans will be hard to attain even in the case when those surveys include a "MENA" category.

For a politicized identity, like MENA American identity, what are the consequences of being unable to self-categorize? Across two experimental studies conducted in April 2022 and October 2024 through January 2025, I re-substantiate that MENA Americans prefer to self-categorize as "MENA" and that MENA identity is politically meaningful for issues that target their group, both foreign and domestic. I also show that this effect spills over to issues that relate to people of color, more broadly. When MENA individuals are unable to self-categorize, they face a form of identity denial known as categorization threat. In response, MENA individuals answer survey questions related to their identity group/groups in ways that reassert their identity.

Beyond the question of which categories we should use to group people, I show the consequences of not including categories that align with people's identities. This mismatch is not bureaucratic mundanity and extends beyond MENA Americans or ethnoracial identity alone. Individuals have always held multifaceted identities, but contemporary research and public discourse increasingly recognize their complexity and fluidity. As a result, more people find themselves caught

²⁸ This is also seen among Latinos who do not wish to be categorized as "Latinx" (Roman and d'Urso 2024).

between the identities they wish to claim and the categories institutions provide. This article shows how categorization threat leads to identity assertion among MENA Americans, revealing the broader consequences of institutional miscategorization. The absence of appropriate categories not only marginalizes communities but also undermines the accuracy of the data used to govern them. As identities become more visible and politically salient, addressing the consequences of category exclusion is essential, both for the integrity of social science and for democratic inclusion.

SUPPLEMENTARY MATERIAL

To view supplementary material for this article, please visit <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055425100919>.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Research documentation and data that support the findings of this study are openly available at the American Political Science Review Dataverse: <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/H62FLL>.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The author thanks the many individuals who helped improve this paper since its first iteration in 2018, especially Matthew D. Nelsen, who helped spark the idea, James Druckman, Kassra Oskooii, Efrén Pérez, Lauren Davenport, Mara Ostfeld, Alex Coppock, Marcel Roman, Aviral Pathak, the APSA DDRIG, and the Rapoport Family Foundation. Additional gratitude is extended to the anonymous reviewers, the APSR editorial board, particularly Editor Marisa Abrajano, and Dragana Svraka for their feedback, guidance, and support.

FUNDING STATEMENT

This research was funded by the American Political Science Association's Doctoral Dissertation Research Improvement Grant and the Rapoport Family Foundation Dissertation Grant.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST

The author declares no ethical issues or conflicts of interest in this research.

ETHICAL STANDARDS

The author declares the human subject research in this article was reviewed by Northwestern University for Studies 1 and 3 (STU00214213), and Georgetown University for Studies 2 (STU00214213) and 3

(MOD00016929). The author affirms this article adheres to the principles concerning research with human participants laid out in APSA's Principles and Guidance on Human Subject Research (2020).

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